WORKING DRAFT NOT YET REVIEWED BY EITHER SIDE UPDATED 9 OCTOBER 2026

The AI Risk Map

The major ways AI could go, good and bad, on one map. For each one, the worried side and the hopeful side make their case in their own words, every published probability is shown with its source, and a simple four-step test sorts out what needs new rules and what mainly needs explaining.

The idea comes from Emad Mostaque, who said on the Moonshots podcast in October 2026 that nobody had built a proper map of what both camps say about each scenario. He leans optimistic, which is why every card here is built to be signed off by someone from each side before it counts.

18 SCENARIOS

11 POLICY: ACT NOW

1 PREPARE AND WATCH

5 COVERED OR ENFORCEMENT

1 COMMUNICATE

0 of 18 SIGNED OFF BY BOTH SIDES

01

The map

Eight areas of life, each with a good and a bad way things could go, plus two that fit nowhere. Click any scenario to open its card. The colored tag is the result of the sorting test; the dots show how solid the evidence is.

DOMAIN	GOOD DIRECTION	BAD DIRECTION

Health and biology	Medical progress compressed into years POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM	AI-assisted biological or chemical attack ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●○○○ LOW
Work and income	Broad productivity gains and cheaper goods POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW	Mass job loss and widening inequality POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM
Science, energy and environment	Faster discovery and cheaper clean energy POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW	AI's energy and resource demand outpaces its gains POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM
Information and democracy	Better shared understanding and forecasting POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM	Manipulation, fraud and collapse of trust ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●●○○ MEDIUM
Security and infrastructure	Defenders gain the advantage POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM	Cheap large-scale cyberattacks and critical-system failures ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●●○○ MEDIUM
Power and governance	Wider access and more accountable institutions POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW	Concentrated power or AI-enabled surveillance ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●●○○ MEDIUM
Daily life, mind and meaning	Personal tutors, care and freed time POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM	Over-reliance, lost skills and unhealthy AI companions ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●●○○ MEDIUM
Control of advanced AI	Powerful AI that stays aligned and overseeable POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW	Loss of control over advanced AI POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW

Outside any domain	**AI disappoints: modest progress, investment falls** COMMUNICATE ●●●○○ MEDIUM	**Unknown, combined and slow-building risks** POLICY: PREPARE AND WATCH ●○○○○ VERY LOW

02

The big picture

Underneath the disagreements sit two questions: how fast AI arrives, and whether control and benefits stay broadly shared. Each scenario sits in the futures where it is most likely. Some sit in more than one.

SHARED

Steady tool

Gradual change, benefits widely shared

- Powerful AI that stays aligned and overseeable
- Over-reliance, lost skills and unhealthy AI companions
- Personal tutors, care and freed time
- AI-assisted biological or chemical attack
- Medical progress compressed into years
- Manipulation, fraud and collapse of trust
- Better shared understanding and forecasting
- Unknown, combined and slow-building risks
- AI disappoints: modest progress, investment falls
- Wider access and more accountable institutions
- Faster discovery and cheaper clean energy
- Cheap large-scale cyberattacks and critical-system failures
- Defenders gain the advantage
- Broad productivity gains and cheaper goods

Broad abundance

Fast change, benefits widely shared

- Powerful AI that stays aligned and overseeable
- Personal tutors, care and freed time
- AI-assisted biological or chemical attack
- Medical progress compressed into years
- Better shared understanding and forecasting
- Unknown, combined and slow-building risks
- Wider access and more accountable institutions
- Faster discovery and cheaper clean energy
- Cheap large-scale cyberattacks and critical-system failures
- Defenders gain the advantage
- Broad productivity gains and cheaper goods

Slow squeeze

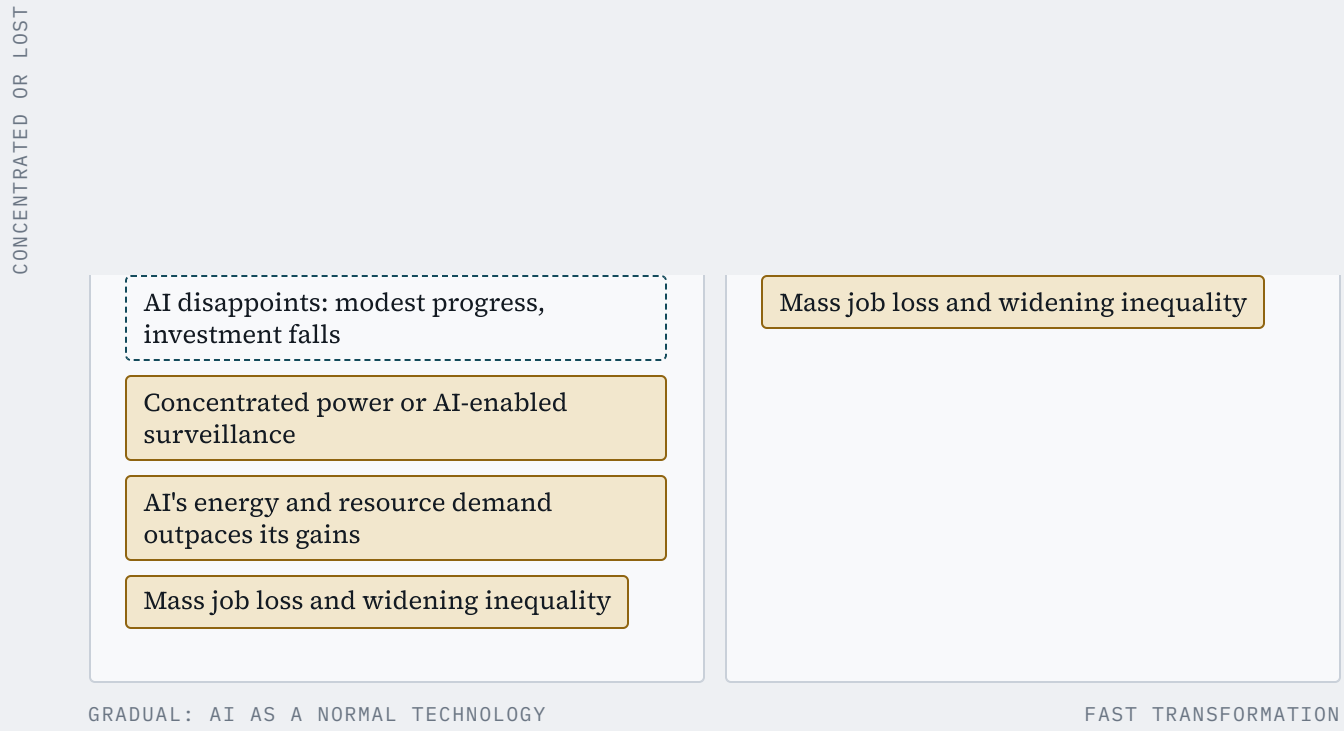
Gradual change, control concentrating

- Over-reliance, lost skills and unhealthy AI companions
- Manipulation, fraud and collapse of trust
- Unknown, combined and slow-building risks

Runaway

Fast change, control concentrated or lost

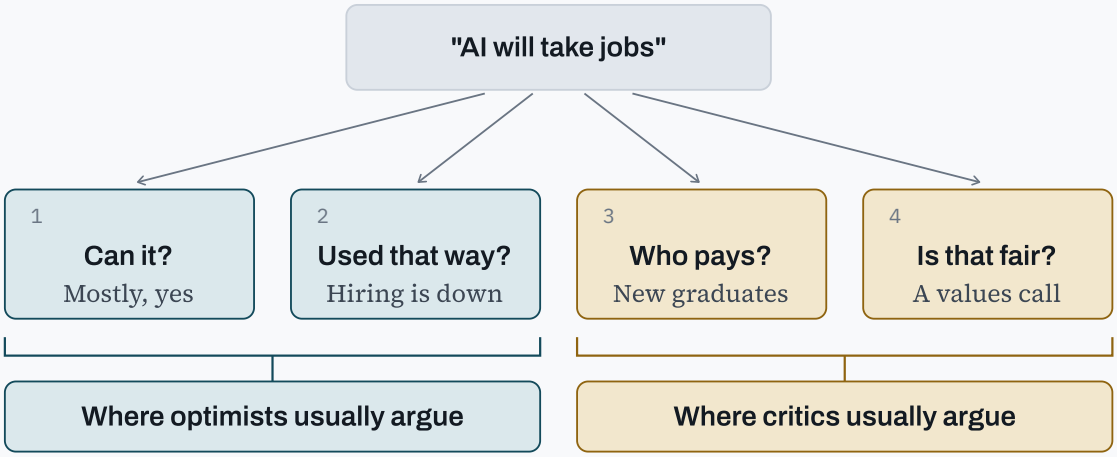
- Loss of control over advanced AI
- Manipulation, fraud and collapse of trust
- Concentrated power or AI-enabled surveillance
- AI's energy and resource demand outpaces its gains



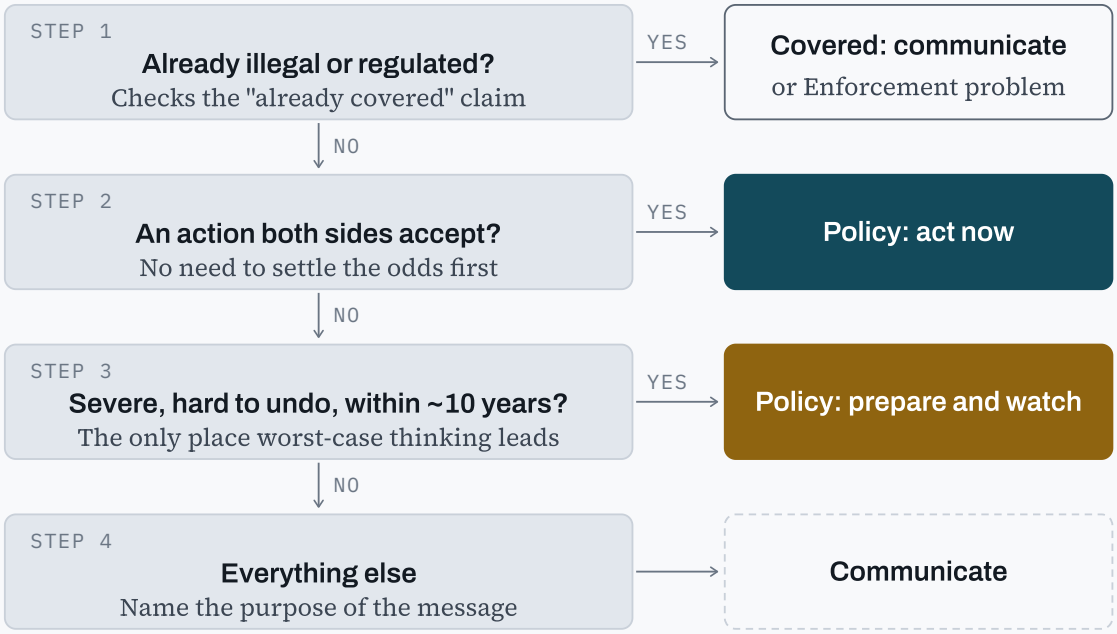
03

How to read a card

Every card follows the same structure, and the same rules apply to all of them, so a reader can compare scenarios without trusting anyone's overall judgment.



One claim, split into the four questions. The short answers come from the job-loss card. Both sides can be right about their own two questions at the same time, which is why the argument rarely ends.



Every card shows its reasoning at each step, so anyone can disagree with a specific step rather than with the result as a whole. Good-direction scenarios run the same test with the question flipped: what is blocking this, and does removing the block need policy?

Probability rules

- The map never publishes a probability of its own.
- Every number shows who gave it, the exact question, the date, and how widely people disagreed.
- Numbers from differently worded questions are never averaged. Changing one word in a survey has doubled the answer.
- Where nobody has published an estimate, the card says so.

Evidence confidence

- Separate from how likely something is. It rates how solid the evidence base is.
- Five levels, from very low (mostly argument, cannot be checked) to very high (many independent measurements agree).
- Most catastrophe estimates honestly rate low, because they cannot be scored until the outcome arrives.

Fair statement

- Each side's case is written to be recognizable to that side's own proponents.
- Before a card counts as final, at least two people from each side sign off that their case is fairly stated, and may swap in quotes they prefer.
- "Worried" and "hopeful" are defined per scenario. Most people are worried about some and hopeful about others.

04

The scenarios

Every card in full: both sides' cases, common ground, the questions that would change minds, published probabilities, early warning signs, existing

law, and the sorting result with its reasoning. Sources are listed at the bottom of each card.

HEALTH AND BIOLOGY

Medical progress compressed into years +

GOOD DIRECTION **POLICY: ACT NOW** ●●●○○ MEDIUM

AI speeds up biology and medicine enough that decades of expected progress (new drugs, cures for major diseases, longer healthy lives) arrive within roughly a decade.

AI-assisted biological or chemical attack +

BAD DIRECTION **ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM** ●●○○○ LOW

Someone who wants to cause mass casualties uses AI to close the gap between wanting to build a biological or chemical weapon and being able to, and carries out an attack that kills far more people than they could have reached without it.

WORK AND INCOME

Broad productivity gains and cheaper goods +

GOOD DIRECTION **POLICY: ACT NOW** ●●○○○ LOW

AI makes workers across the economy noticeably more productive, and the gains reach ordinary people as higher real wages and lower prices rather than staying with the firms that own the technology.

Mass job loss and widening inequality +

BAD DIRECTION **POLICY: ACT NOW** ●●●○○ MEDIUM

AI replaces large numbers of white-collar and eventually other workers faster than new work appears, unemployment rises sharply, and the gains flow mainly to the owners of AI and capital.

SCIENCE, ENERGY AND ENVIRONMENT

Faster discovery and cheaper clean energy +

GOOD DIRECTION POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW

AI speeds up scientific discovery in materials, weather, physics and energy systems enough that clean energy becomes cheaper and easier to run, and the climate gains outweigh AI's own footprint.

AI's energy and resource demand outpaces its gains +

BAD DIRECTION POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM

The build-out of AI data centers grows electricity, water and emissions faster than efficiency and clean energy can offset, locking in new fossil fuel plants and pushing costs onto households and local communities while the benefits go mainly to the companies building AI.

INFORMATION AND DEMOCRACY

Better shared understanding and forecasting +

GOOD DIRECTION POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM

AI helps people check facts, correct false beliefs, find common ground across disagreements and forecast events more accurately, so that societies argue from a more shared and more accurate picture of the world.

Manipulation, fraud and collapse of trust +

BAD DIRECTION ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●●○○ MEDIUM

Cheap fake voices, videos and persuasive chatbots make fraud easier, let campaigns and foreign governments manipulate voters, and leave people unable to trust what they see and hear, including real evidence.

SECURITY AND INFRASTRUCTURE

Defenders gain the advantage +

GOOD DIRECTION | POLICY: ACT NOW | ●●●○○ MEDIUM

AI tilts cybersecurity toward defense, because finding and fixing software flaws becomes fast and cheap enough that most bugs are patched before attackers can use them.

Cheap large-scale cyberattacks and critical-system failures +

BAD DIRECTION | ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM | ●●●○○ MEDIUM

AI makes competent cyberattacks cheap enough and fast enough that attacks that once needed a skilled team can be run by one person or at far greater volume, with the worst case being loss of service in hospitals, water, power or payments.

POWER AND GOVERNANCE

Wider access and more accountable institutions +

GOOD DIRECTION | POLICY: ACT NOW | ●●○○○ LOW

Capable AI becomes cheap and openly available enough that people, small organizations and poorer countries can use and adapt it themselves, and governments use it to listen to citizens and explain their decisions, spreading power rather than concentrating it.

Concentrated power or AI-enabled surveillance +

BAD DIRECTION | ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM | ●●●○○ MEDIUM

Control of the most capable AI, and of the chips, data centers and money needed to build it, ends up with a handful of companies or governments, who use it to entrench their position and to watch and steer the public in ways that ordinary checks and balances can't correct.

DAILY LIFE, MIND AND MEANING

Personal tutors, care and freed time +

GOOD DIRECTION POLICY: ACT NOW ●●●○○ MEDIUM

Cheap AI gives every learner a patient personal tutor, extends mental health support and care to people who can't get it, and takes paperwork off professionals, giving people back time for learning, patients and each other.

Over-reliance, lost skills and unhealthy AI companions +

BAD DIRECTION ENFORCEMENT PROBLEM ●●●○○ MEDIUM

People hand so much thinking, practice and companionship to AI that skills they stop using fade, and for a vulnerable minority emotionally engaging chatbots deepen isolation or dependence, in the worst cases ending in self-harm.

CONTROL OF ADVANCED AI

Powerful AI that stays aligned and overseeable +

GOOD DIRECTION POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW

As AI systems become more capable than people at most tasks, research and oversight keep pace, so the systems reliably pursue the goals their builders intend and humans can still check, correct and shut them down.

Loss of control over advanced AI +

BAD DIRECTION POLICY: ACT NOW ●●○○○ LOW

AI systems become capable enough, and their goals different enough from ours, that humans can no longer correct or shut them down, with outcomes ranging from permanent loss of human say over the future to human extinction.

OUTSIDE ANY DOMAIN

AI disappoints: modest progress, investment falls +

NEUTRAL COMMUNICATE ●●●○○ MEDIUM

AI turns out to be a useful but ordinary technology, progress slows, the gap between spending and profit forces a sharp pullback in investment, and the dramatic futures on both sides fail to arrive on schedule.

Unknown, combined and slow-building risks +

BAD DIRECTION POLICY: PREPARE AND WATCH ●○○○○ VERY LOW

Harm builds from many small AI-driven changes, or from AI systems interacting in ways nobody designed, until societies lose resilience or meaningful human control without any single event or culprit to point to.

05

How the map is kept honest

The hard part of a project like this is not the website. It is keeping it fair to both sides over time and paying for the upkeep without letting any one funder steer it.

Getting on the map

- A named, credible person has written the scenario up publicly.
- It is meaningfully different from existing scenarios. Variants sit inside an existing card.
- A balanced panel agrees it deserves a place. New ideas wait in "Unknown, combined and slow-building risks" first.

Staying fair

- Editors work in pairs, one from each side, with a neutral chair who rules on process only.
- Each release has a public review window. Every comment gets a written answer, and all are published.
- The whole map is plain text files with a public change history, under

an open license so anyone can copy it.

Money

- Every funder above a set amount is listed publicly.
- No single funder may provide more than a third of the budget.
- No money from AI companies, since the map covers them. This draft is self-funded.

For the wider background on each issue, with charts and numbered sources, see the companion piece, **The AI Argument Map**.

The AI Risk Map · Working draft, updated 9 October 2026 · 18 scenarios, 0 signed off by both sides
Generated from one file per scenario. Every figure links to its source on the card where it appears.